The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

The United Arab Emirates said it would leave the **Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries** on May 1st, after six decades of membership. The departure is likely to weaken a group that supplies around a third of the world's oil. The UAE—which in 2025 was the cartel's third-largest producer and has long chafed at OPEC's constraints on its output—recently criticised its neighbours in the Gulf for not doing enough to defend it against attacks from Iran, another member.

Donald Trump claimed **Iran** had told America it was in a "state of collapse" and wanted the Strait of Hormuz reopened "as soon as possible". Officials in Iran have not confirmed this. Mr Trump also lashed out at Friedrich Merz, Germany's chancellor, saying he "doesn't know what he's talking about", after Mr Merz said America was being "humiliated" by Iran.

An **Israeli strike** in the southern **Lebanese** town of Majdal Zoun, near the countries' border, wounded two soldiers and trapped three rescuers under rubble, according to the Lebanese army. The attack hit troops and emergency workers during a rescue operation, despite an American-brokered ceasefire. Lebanon's health ministry

said at least 2,534 people have been killed and 7,863 wounded since early March.

BMG and **Concord**, two of the largest independent music labels, agreed to merge to create the world's fourth-biggest music firm. The new entity is expected to generate $2.2bn in revenue in 2026 and will own the rights to work by artists such as Miles Davis and R.E.M. Bertelsmann, the media group that owns BMG, plans to cut jobs.

BYD, China's biggest electric carmaker, reported annual net profits of $590m—a fall of more than 50% from the previous year. While demand for its EVs in other countries rose, fierce competition in its home market had led to a drop in domestic sales. The manufacturer resorted to slashing prices and developing ultra-fast charging technology to stay ahead, reducing profit margins.

British MPs voted against opening an inquiry into whether **Sir Keir Starmer** misled parliament over his appointment of **Peter Mandelson** as ambassador to America. The motion, brought by the opposition Conservative Party, was defeated by a wide margin as Labour MPs voted it down. A finding that he misled parliament could have intensified calls for Sir Kier's resignation.

BP reported profits of $3.2bn for the first quarter, its highest first-quarter result since 2023 and more than double the same period last year. The war in Iran has caused energy prices to spike, with other oil majors benefiting from the energy-supply crunch. The firm said its margins and upstream production—which involves the exploration, drilling and extraction of crude oil—would "remain sensitive" to the conflict.

Figure of the day: 40%, the share of South Koreans aged 65 and over who remain in work. Read our story on why older people in East Asia are staying in the labour force.

Photograph: Getty Images

Purdue’s final reckoning

Purdue Pharma—arguably the biggest contributor to America’s opioid crisis—will return to court on Tuesday for a criminal sentencing. The drugmaker has admitted to deceptively marketing OxyContin, its highly addictive painkiller, and paying kickbacks to doctors to prescribe it. Purdue entered bankruptcy seven years ago, swamped by lawsuits from state and local governments and opioid users. The hearing is one of the final steps needed to unlock compensation.

Under the deal the firm and its former owners, the Sackler family, will pay up to $7bn to claimants over 15 years. Most will go to states and municipalities for drug treatment. Individuals will share a far smaller pool—around $850m—distributed according to the severity of harm. Anyone who lost a relative to an OxyContin addiction is expected to pocket between $7,000 and $48,000, an unsatisfyingly small resolution. And the public-health crisis itself is anything but resolved: around 45,000 Americans die of opioid deaths a year.

Photograph: EPA

How low can the yen go?

The Bank of Japan held rates at 0.75% when it concluded its two-day meeting on Tuesday. America's Federal Reserve and the Bank of England, issuing decisions this week, will probably do the same. Most central banks have responded to the economic uncertainty caused by the Iran war by temporarily pausing cycles of cutting.

Analysts will be watching what the BoJ's decision means for the yen, which remains stubbornly weak despite two years of hikes (after 17 years of negative interest rates). At nearly ¥160 to the dollar, the currency is close to a three-decade low. In his press conference on Tuesday, the BoJ's governor, Ueda Kazuo, helped boost the yen by adopting a hawkish tone. Most analysts expect a rate rise in June. Yet a sharp tightening looks unlikely: Japan's high public debt and the prime minister's loose fiscal stance leave little room for the bank to move.

Photograph: Getty Images

Can Starbucks perk up?

Starbucks reports its quarterly earnings on Tuesday. The world's largest coffee chain has recently looked lukewarm: ground down by rising takeaway orders (on which it earns smaller margins) and trendy upstarts like Blank Street, an American chain. Brian Niccol, Starbuck's boss, wants to return to the brand's coffeehouse origins by hiring more staff and encouraging customers to have their drinks in-store. So far, it seems to have worked: in its previous earnings, released in January, Starbucks reported rising sales in its stores for the first time in two years. The company's stock price has increased by more than 10% from the October average. Now analysts hope profits will heat up too.

Mr Niccol reckons coffee-drinkers want a welcoming "third space" outside work and home. Meanwhile Starbucks' main rivals—particularly Chinese companies like Luckin, Mixue and Chagee—prioritise efficiency: robots staff some of their stores. As these chains enter the American market, consumers' preference for comfort over convenience will be tested.

Photograph: Getty Images

A new anti-fossil fuel forum in Colombia

The UN's annual climate summit in November was dominated by arguments over governments creating "roadmaps" for weaning themselves off fossil fuels (their pledge from 2023). When countries could not agree to commit even to talking about the concept or what it actually meant, the Colombian and Dutch delegations announced they would host their own international summit on the issue instead.

That conference begins on Tuesday, in the Colombian city of Santa Marta. Ministers from more than 50 countries will attend, alongside climate, economic and technology experts. Predictably, America, China and the Gulf states are not among them. Still, the countries represented collectively produce about a fifth of the world's fossil fuels, and turmoil in oil and gas markets has made transitioning to renewables a more attractive proposition.

Those frustrated by international climate diplomacy should not expect radical changes, however. The conference's aim is to come up with a "menu of solutions" to augment the formal UN process, rather than upend it.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which breed of horse, originating in England, was notable for its strength, being used to pull canal boats and brewers' carts, as well as farm equipment?

Monday: Which character is the main archenemy of the Fantastic Four, in both the comic book and film series?

Real stupidity beats artificial intelligence every time.

Terry Pratchett